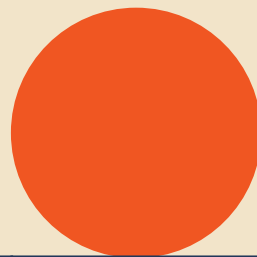


Public Speaking

 MasterClass



Why Is Everyone Looking at You?

Oh, right. It's because you've got something important to say. With the right words and effective delivery, you have the potential to captivate, motivate, or move your audience in this moment. Feeling a little anxious? That's okay. As the old saying goes, there are only two types of public speakers: Those who are nervous and those who are liars.

Here's the good news: Public speaking isn't rocket science. Success is a matter of employing a few simple (but important) strategies. This guide will lay some of them out for you. By using it as a framework, you'll be able to develop the skills needed to excel when all eyes are on you—whether you're pitching a new idea, rallying your team, or giving a wedding toast. Take a deep breath. You've got this. Let's get to work.

MICRO LESSON: BODY LANGUAGE

- > If possible, move around a bit when you're speaking.
- > Use active hand gestures to create energy and hold the audience's attention.
- > Remember: Good posture and a friendly smile can work wonders.

TRY THIS

If you're prone to saying *um*, *kinda*, or *like* when you talk, try recording yourself giving a brief off-the-cuff speech. Review the audio, noting when you use filler words. Now try giving the speech again—it doesn't need to be verbatim, focus on going slower and eliminating filler words. Keep practicing until you get through the whole thing smoothly at a comfortable pace.



**“If you’re thinking,
‘Oh my goodness,
everyone’s looking
at me.’ Good.
You’re fabulous.”**

— RUPAUL

What's Your Message?

Understand the reason you're stepping up to speak

Knowing what you're trying to say—even if not every syllable—is absolutely essential. “It’s not simply the words that matter,” says award-winning historian and biographer Doris Kearns Goodwin. She’s an expert on former U.S. president Franklin D. Roosevelt, whose famed radio broadcasts boosted support for new social programs and kept the public apprised of U.S. activities during WWII. “What you’re really hoping [for] from a speech is that you’re mobilizing people to take some sort of action or to feel different about something.”

Start with defining a clear purpose (why are you giving this presentation?) and the desired outcomes (what action do you need from others?). Consider what information you’ll need to provide in order to achieve

these goals, and, when appropriate, how you’ll inspire an emotional response from listeners. The stakes of your speech may not be as high as Roosevelt’s, but you should always offer clarity and substance—especially if your audience is a team of busy coworkers.

“What makes a great speech, fundamentally, is whether it produces action.”

— DORIS KEARNS GOODWIN

TRY THIS

To ensure your speech has direction, map the impact you’d like to have on your audience in three sections:

> What do they need to learn?

> What do they need to feel?

> What do you want them to do?



Who's in the Crowd?

On the importance of tailoring your message to the listener

Resonating with your audience goes beyond the purpose of your message. To leave a lasting impression, you'll need to think about how your words are packaged—and who they're packaged for. Every group of listeners is different, host to a unique set of experiences, views, and circumstances. There's also the reason they have gathered. A funeral procession probably won't appreciate a rapid volley of jokes in the style of a wedding speech.

On this matter, Neil deGrasse Tyson is an expert. As a public intellectual and accomplished astrophysicist, he's often asked to give high school graduation speeches. He knows that each class is different. So his commencement remarks are different, too. For example, if the audience is predomi-

nantly made up of girls, he might address sexism and acknowledge its practical challenges in certain professions. If many of the students are from low-income households, he may "add some examples of people who overcame not having [many] resources" and dedicate more time to discussing collegiate scholarship programs.

According to Neil, the degree to which you're considerate of your crowd can open them up to your ideas—or leave them convinced you have nothing to offer. To keep your audience close, you'll want to mold your message to make it compatible with them. "Otherwise, there's two ships passing in the night," Neil says. "You'll be lecturing and not communicating."

TRY THIS

To hone the message delivered to your audience, make an empathy map with four sections:

> What does the group already know?

> What do they want to get out of this talk?

> What assumptions and biases might they have?

> What gets them excited and interested?

Will It Resonate?

You know your audience, why you're speaking to them, and what you're going to say in the broadest sense. Here's how to make it stick

Public-speaking experts suggest keeping your tone somewhat casual, even when talking about something as imperative as the state of the nation. "I've always favored, whenever possible, the maximum amount of conversational style because...if I'm just talking to you, you'll probably listen," says former U.S. president Bill Clinton. "Making the audience feel that you are speaking directly to them is crucial."

That's not to say that you should wing it. Rather, preparing your most important points—even if there are only two or three of them—beforehand can give your speech structure and ensure you don't accidentally stumble off track. But beware: Overplanning your speech can make you appear stiff and insincere, which probably won't appeal to your audience. Avoid reading what you've written down verbatim.

So how do you balance the casualness of an informal dinner chat with the strong direction of a good essay? You tell a story. It's easier to memorize than the particulars behind a list of points—and the results are much more entertaining. When you spin a yarn embedded with your overarching ideas, you can help the audience to see themselves in your words.

"When you share a story, you actually bring

MICRO LESSON: EYE CONTACT

- > If you're speaking to a large group, look over the crowd's eyeline. This makes it appear as though you're looking at everyone.
- > In a smaller crowd, find one person who's making direct eye contact with you. Speak to them. Let your confidence build. Then start to look at different audience members. Keep moving around until you've glanced at everybody.
- > As for the audience member staring at their phone? They'll only end up distracting you. Ignore them.



in that human side to it,” says Malala Yousafzai, the international human rights activist who has delivered speeches at the United Nations. “People start connecting with it, and they understand the emotions and the feelings behind it—why it is important.”

If you position the human elements—personal, entertaining, and sometimes even poignant—within easy reach of the audience, your speech will end the same way that every good one does: The listeners will remember what you said.

“The simplest advice you could get: Talk to the audience as if you’re telling them something interesting!”

— JUDD APATOW

TRY THIS

Before you step up to speak, double-check to make sure you’re prepared using this checklist:

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Establish your purpose | ☐ Create bullet points to practice without reading |
| ☐ Consider your audience | ☐ Breathe to relax the nerves before speaking |
| ☐ Outline your story | ☐ Set up your hook |
| ☐ Use humor and analogies to make your point | ☐ Build in questions |

